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What’s with Data Analytics for Marketing & Media agencies in 2025 & beyond.

This is a Microsoft PowerPoint deck in which Nkateko Mongwe uses his expertise to author a view for Data Analytics for the Marketing & Media agencies in 2025 onwards.

This is a interesting view that scopes out where data is currently in 2025 and highlights how data can be used to gain a competitive advantage.

From sense checking measurement & reporting to listing methods of data collection within an analytics framework.

What the view is about:

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Who am I ?

- I am a seasoned data analyst with over 13 years experience. I am a highly determined, passionately dedicated professional who is self-motivated.
- My expertise spans across data analysis, digital campaign performance reporting, and the development of strategic insights to drive business impact.
- I have worked on high-profile accounts including Vodacom, Old Mutual, Cell C, and Mr Price, delivering actionable insights through tools such as Looker Studio, Power BI, SQL, Adobe Analytics, and Google Tag Manager.
- Known for my ability to translate complex data into clear narratives, I bring a solutions-driven mindset, strong storytelling skills, and a passion for using data to solve real business problems.
- I am continuously upskilling in areas such as web analytics, server-side tracking, and data science to stay at the forefront of the evolving digital analytics landscape.
- Destiny brought me to data in marketing & media. I have authored an article that credited me with a live interview on Sabc Africa's Media Monitoring show.
- I have been a contributing member of four industry boards. Thanks to AMASA & Vega, I have also guest lectured Media Math as well as Media Research quite a few times.
- I am big on delivering efficiency as well as being effective as a data professional.
- Fortunate to have the experience of being in all sides of the supply chain across the industry, I have demonstrated expertise in providing value with data.
- The tools I have knowledge in are: Google Analytics; Adobe Analytics; SQL; Power B.I; Looker; Looker Studio; Datorama; Advanced Excel; Telmar; AppsFlyer; Firebase; Google Marketing Platform; Google Cloud; Google Big Query; GWI; Euro Monitor; Statista; Nielsen AdIntel; Arianna; Transmitt; Radio Max



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What’s with Data Maturity…

✓ 1. Stratified Maturity Levels

Global holding companies (e.g., GroupM, Omnicom, Publicis, Dentsu) tend to lead in data maturity. They've invested in proprietary platforms, centralized data lakes, and integrated tools for analytics, planning, and measurement.
Mid-size and independent agencies often lag, relying on piecemeal solutions and facing challenges around interoperability, talent, and scalable processes.

📊 2. Advanced Reporting, Lagging Predictive Capabilities

Most agencies have automated dashboards (Looker Studio, Power BI, Tableau) and standardized campaign reporting in place.
However, predictive analytics, AI-driven personalization, and media mix modeling are still emerging capabilities—not widely implemented or deeply integrated into strategy.

🔄 3. Shift Toward First-Party Data & Clean Rooms

Privacy regulations (like GDPR, POPIA, and the deprecation of cookies) have accelerated the push toward first-party data strategies.
Agencies are increasingly partnering with clean room platforms (Google PAIR, InfoSum, Habu) to facilitate privacy-compliant targeting and measurement.

🧠 4. Skills Gap and Data Talent Bottleneck

Many agencies face a shortage of hybrid talent—professionals who can bridge creative/media planning with data science and tech.
Data analysts are still siloed in many setups, often brought in post-strategy rather than embedded at the planning stage.



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What’s with Data Maturity…

🛠️ 5. MarTech/AdTech Integration is a Pain Point

A major hurdle remains the lack of full MarTech and AdTech stack integration—especially between CRM platforms, DSPs, CDPs, and creative personalization engines.
Disparate data sources limit real-time optimization and holistic performance views.

🌍 6. South African Context

Agencies in South Africa and broader MEA regions are catching up—many are strong in basic reporting and post-campaign analysis, but predictive insights, real-time dashboards, and integrated CDPs are still emerging.

Skills and budget constraints are often the primary blockers to greater maturity, despite growing interest.

🔮 Looking Ahead: What’s Next

AI/ML for creative optimization, automated segmentation, and cross-channel attribution will define the next leap in data maturity.

Agencies are under pressure to prove ROI more rigorously—making data-driven strategy a competitive differentiator.



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Checking In with Measurement

1. Data Integrity & Privacy Compliance

Sense Check: Are we collecting, storing, and reporting data in a way that complies with evolving privacy regulations (e.g., POPIA, GDPR, CPRA) and platform restrictions (e.g., cookie deprecation, Meta/Google data limitations)?
•Validate source data accuracy and completeness.
•Ensure consent mechanisms are in place and respected.
•Use privacy-safe modeling (e.g., MMM, clean rooms) where granular tracking isn't possible.

✔ **Sense Check:** *Are we collecting, storing, and reporting data in compliance with privacy laws and platform shifts?*

🔍 **Practical Example:**
•**Issue:** A campaign uses Meta pixel for conversion tracking.
•**Check:** Is data still being captured accurately after Apple's iOS 17 privacy changes and Chrome's phasing out of third-party cookies?
•**Action:** Implement **Google's Enhanced Conversions**, **Meta's Conversion API**, or **clean rooms** (e.g., Google Ads Data Hub or Amazon Marketing Cloud) to maintain measurement without relying on third-party cookies.

🗄 **Source References:**
•Google Ads Blog: Enhanced Conversions
•Meta for Developers: Meta Conversion API
•Gartner (2024): *"Post-cookie measurement: First-party data strategy is critical"*



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Checking In with Measurement

2. Holistic Attribution & KPI Alignment

Sense Check: Are we attributing impact across the full funnel and linking media metrics to true business outcomes?
•Avoid over-reliance on last-click or siloed platform metrics.
•Combine media data with CRM, conversion, and sales data for full-funnel insights.
•Tie campaign performance to business objectives (e.g., customer growth, revenue, LTV).

✔ **Sense Check:** *Are we attributing value across the full funnel and aligned with business KPIs, not just media metrics?*

🔍 **Practical Example:**
•**Issue:** A campaign reports high impressions and clicks, but client revenue hasn't increased.
•**Check:** Are upper-funnel metrics being correlated to downstream conversions and ROAS?
•**Action:** Use **Marketing Mix Modeling (MMM)** alongside **multi-touch attribution (MTA)** and **data from CRM systems** to understand actual impact. Align dashboards to show *cost per lead, ROAS, LTV, and assisted conversions*, not just CTR.

🗄 **Source References:**
•Nielsen: Marketing Mix Modeling Essentials
•Think with Google (2024): *"How brands can measure success in a privacy-first future"*
•HubSpot: Marketing KPIs That Matter



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Checking In with Measurement

3. Benchmarking, Baselines & Actionability

Sense Check: Are we comparing performance against meaningful baselines and delivering insights that drive optimization?
•Use historical trends, category benchmarks, and platform norms.
•Differentiate between statistical significance and performance variance.
•Ensure reporting leads to actionable recommendations, not just data dumps.

✔ **Sense Check:** *Are performance insights benchmarked and truly actionable, not just observational?*

🔍 **Practical Example:**
•**Issue:** Weekly reporting shows drop in CTR but lacks context.
•**Check:** Is the dip significant compared to category benchmarks or seasonality trends?
•**Action:** Create **category benchmarks** (e.g., finance, telco, FMCG) and **internal performance baselines**. Layer in **statistical significance testing** and visual indicators (e.g., "↑5% vs. last 6-month average") in Looker Studio or Power BI.

🗄 **Source References:**
•Statista / eMarketer: Industry-specific benchmarks
•Supermetrics: Marketing benchmarks dashboard templates
•Think with Google: *"Using benchmarks to improve paid media performance"*



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Elementary trends within Analytics

1. AI-Driven Insights and Automation

AI and ML are now core components of analytics tools, enabling predictive models, NLP-powered dashboards, and auto-generated insights.

📌 Source: McKinsey & Company – "The state of AI in 2023: Generative AI's breakout year"
📎 mckinsey.com

2. Real-Time and Streaming Analytics

Businesses are investing in platforms like Apache Kafka and Spark to support instantaneous data processing and analytics.

📌 Source: Gartner – "Top Trends in Data and Analytics for 2023"
📎 gartner.com

3. Privacy-First Data Collection and Analytics

The focus on zero-party and first-party data is intensifying in response to global data privacy regulations.

📌 Source: Deloitte – "Privacy in Analytics: Balancing Insight and Compliance"
📎 deloitte.com

4. Data Democratization and Self-Service BI

BI tools with self-service capabilities are being adopted to allow business users to generate their own insights.

📌 Source: Forrester – "The Future of Business Intelligence Is Self-Service"
📎 forrester.com



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Elementary trends within Analytics

5. Data Governance and Quality Management

As analytics scales, maintaining data accuracy and governance is key to enterprise confidence and regulatory alignment.

📌 Source: Accenture – "Data Governance: From Policy to Practice"
📎 accenture.com

6. Embedded and Augmented Analytics

Platforms are integrating analytics into core business tools, leveraging NLP and AI for contextual insights.

📌 Source: Tableau – "The Future of Analytics: Embedded and Augmented Intelligence"
📎 tableau.com

7. Predictive and Prescriptive Analytics

Advanced analytics is evolving toward decision intelligence—suggesting optimal business actions based on forecasts.

📌 Source: MIT Sloan Management Review – "From Predictive to Prescriptive Analytics"
📎 sloanreview.mit.edu



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Essential methods for collecting data

🔷 1. Web & Digital Analytics Methods

These are used to track user interactions on websites, mobile apps, and digital platforms.

1. **Page Tagging (JavaScript Tags)** – Using tools like Google Analytics or Adobe Analytics to track user behavior (clicks, pageviews, etc.)
2. **Cookies and Tracking Pixels** – Small data files and images to monitor users across sessions and channels.
3. **Event Tracking** – Tracking specific actions like button clicks, video plays, downloads.
4. **UTM Parameters** – URL parameters to track campaign performance across traffic sources.
5. **Session Recording & Heatmaps** – Tools like Hotjar or Crazy Egg capture on-screen user behavior.
6. **A/B and Multivariate Testing** – Collecting comparative performance data across different content or layout variations.
7. **Mobile SDK Tracking** – Embedded in apps to collect usage and engagement data (e.g., Firebase, Mixpanel).



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Essential methods for collecting data

🔷 2. Server-Side & Backend Methods

For more control, security, and accuracy in data collection.

1. **Server Logs Analysis** – Parsing raw log files for visits, requests, and errors.
2. **API-based Data Ingestion** – Pulling structured data from internal or external systems (e.g., Salesforce, HubSpot).
3. **Backend Event Tracking** – Custom events triggered and logged server-side.
4. **ETL Pipelines (Extract, Transform, Load)** – Collecting data from multiple sources into a data warehouse (e.g., using tools like Airflow, Fivetran).

🔷 3. Offline & Manual Collection Methods

Often used to supplement digital data or when digital tracking isn't available.

1. **Surveys and Forms** – Customer feedback collected through Google Forms, Typeform, etc.
2. **CRM and POS Data** – Customer interactions, transactions, and sales data.
3. **Manual Data Entry** – Human-entered data from interviews, call centers, or physical audits.



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Essential methods for collecting data

◈ 4. Third-Party & Syndicated Data Sources

External providers and tools offering enriched or contextual data.

1. **Social Media APIs** – Data from platforms like Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn for engagement metrics.
2. **Media & Ad Platforms** – Google Ads, Meta Ads, programmatic platforms provide campaign performance data.
3. **Syndicated Market Data** – Nielsen, Kantar, GWI, etc., for industry-level analytics.

◈ 5. Sensor-Based & IoT Data

Emerging areas involving physical or environmental data.

1. **IoT Devices** – Wearables, smart devices collecting health, usage, or environmental data.
2. **Beacons & RFID** – Used in retail for in-store analytics.
3. **Geolocation & GPS Tracking** – Mobile or vehicle tracking for movement-based analytics.



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Data as a strategic competitive advantage

1. Audience & Consumer Insights

Competitive Advantage: Using data to deeply understand audience behavior, needs, and preferences enables more effective targeting and personalization.

Example: An agency using **first-party CRM data and social listening** can uncover that young professionals engage more with short-form video ads on mobile at lunchtime. This insight informs creative and media planning.

Supporting Source: *"Businesses that leverage customer behavioral insights outperform peers by 85% in sales growth." — McKinsey & Company, 2021;* McKinsey: Driving growth through customer insights

Audience & Consumer Intelligence

Use Case: Leveraging data to understand customer behaviors, preferences, and needs.

Competitive Advantage: Enables hyper-targeted messaging, personalized campaigns, and better segmentation.

•**Example:** Wavemaker used AI-powered insights to refine Vodafone's youth targeting, increasing engagement and conversions (source: WARC).

•**Tools:** Google Analytics 4, Meta Audience Insights, TGI (Target Group Index), GWI (GlobalWebIndex).



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Data as a strategic competitive advantage

2. Campaign Performance & Optimization

Competitive Advantage: Real-time campaign tracking allows agencies to adjust creative, bidding, and targeting mid-flight for better ROI.

Example: Using **Google Analytics 4 and Looker Studio**, an agency notices poor bounce rates from one audience segment. They pause spend for that group and reallocate to high-performing lookalikes.

Supporting Source: *"Real-time data and A/B testing can reduce campaign waste by 30% or more."*
— Harvard Business Review, 2022
HBR: Using Analytics to Drive Marketing ROI

Campaign Performance & Real-Time Optimization

Use Case: Monitoring KPIs in real time to tweak creative, media placements, and budget allocations.
Competitive Advantage: Minimizes media wastage, boosts ROI, and enables agile decision-making.

- **Example:** EssenceMediacom used real-time dashboards to optimize Google campaigns for Google Pixel, improving cost per acquisition (CPA) by over 30%.
- **Tools:** Looker Studio, Google Ads Scripts, Adobe Analytics



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Data as a strategic competitive advantage

3. Strategic Planning & Forecasting

Competitive Advantage: **Data modeling helps agencies predict future performance and plan accordingly.**

Example: **An agency uses** historical media spend, conversion rates, and seasonality trends **to create a forecast model for a retail client's holiday campaign.**

Supporting Source: ***"Predictive analytics improves marketing effectiveness by up to 25%." — Deloitte Insights, 2023***
Deloitte: Future of Marketing

Measurement & Attribution

Use Case: Multi-touch attribution and ROI analysis across channels.

Competitive Advantage: Helps clients understand what's driving conversions and scale the most effective tactics.

- **Example:** Dentsu leveraged Unified Marketing Measurement (MMM + MTA) to demonstrate that YouTube was undervalued in its contribution to sales, which led to budget shifts and performance lifts.

- **Tools:** Nielsen Attribution, Rockerbox, Google's Data-driven Attribution in GA4.



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Data as a strategic competitive advantage

4. Attribution & Measurement

Competitive Advantage: Understanding the role each touchpoint plays in conversion helps optimize channel mix and budget.

Example: Using multi-touch attribution via Adobe Analytics, an agency proves that video ads drive upper-funnel awareness that leads to later conversions through paid search.

Supporting Source: “Advanced attribution models can lift marketing ROI by 15–30%.”
— Gartner, 2021
Gartner: Marketing Performance Measurement

Strategic Forecasting & Media Planning

Use Case: Using historical data, market trends, and predictive models to inform planning.
Competitive Advantage: Enhances precision in media planning and helps win pitches with data-backed strategies.

- **Example:** IPG Mediabrands’ Magna unit uses macroeconomic and media data models to forecast ad spend trends for better media planning across sectors.
- **Tools:** Telmar, Kantar Media Tools, Market Mix Modeling



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Data as a strategic competitive advantage

5. Innovation & Product Development

Competitive Advantage: Data identifies emerging trends and untapped consumer needs, guiding product or content innovation.

Example: Social media and sentiment data reveal growing demand for eco-conscious financial products. The agency advises a banking client to launch a “green savings” product, gaining first-mover advantage.

Supporting Source: “Data-driven innovation is a core driver of long-term brand relevance and growth.”
— Forrester Research, 2023
Forrester: Data-Driven Innovation

Competitive Benchmarking & Market Intelligence

Use Case: Monitoring competitor campaigns, spend, and creative strategies.

Competitive Advantage: Allows brands to outmaneuver competitors and capture share of voice.

- **Example:** Nielsen Ad Intel helped a leading FMCG brand adjust its digital investment after analyzing competitors' media spend in the category, leading to 12% market share growth.
- **Tools:** Nielsen Ad Intel, SEMrush, Pathmatics, Meltwater.



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